

People Skills

The part the tool can't reach.

Everything until now has been about a machine. What it does, how it works, where it breaks, and how not to get played by it. This lesson is about people, and it's the first one here that has nothing to do with the tool.

Here's why it belongs at this point. The day everyone got the same AI, everyone got the same first draft. Your classmates can generate a solid essay. So can the kid who never reads. So can you. When the output stops separating people, something else has to.

AI can synthesize almost anything. It can't be trusted by anyone. People still choose who to work with the way they always have: by who explains things clearly, who does what they said they'd do, and who they believe when it counts. Three skills sit on top of each other here, in order. Each one is more human than the last, and that is exactly the order of how hard they are to hand off.

1. SAY IT SO IT LANDS

AI can write your presentation. Then Thursday comes, and it's you standing up there, and none of the writing helps. Delivery is a live skill. You are watching faces, hearing the room go quiet or go restless, and adjusting while you talk. There is no draft for that.

SAME IDEA, TWO DELIVERIES

One group project on water use in your district. One point to make. Here's the version that came out of a chat window, and the version that works out loud.

WHAT THE DRAFT SAYS

"Our research indicates that residential water consumption in the district has increased 18% over the past decade, driven primarily by outdoor irrigation during the summer months."

WHAT YOU SAY

"Our district uses 18% more water than it did ten years ago. Almost all of the increase goes on lawns, in July and August. We're not drinking more. We're watering more."

Same fact, two builds. One is written to be read. One is built to be heard: short sentences, one number, and a picture you can hold.

Two more moves live inside this one, and both happen while you're talking. Reading the room is noticing you lost people at slide three, and stopping to fix it instead of pushing to slide four. Listening is the harder one, because most people spend the other person's sentence loading their own. When your teammate says "I guess we could cut the survey," the whole message is in the "I guess." Ask about it.

2. BE THE ONE PEOPLE WANT ON THE TEAM

Four people, one slide deck, one grade. AI can write every section of it. What AI cannot do is the part that actually sinks group projects, and it is never the work. It's the guy who stopped answering the group chat five days ago.

Most group problems aren't people being lazy. They're people being something, and you can usually tell which.

THE ONE WHO WENT QUIET

Two check-ins, no reply.

Quiet usually isn't lazy. It's someone who is behind, embarrassed, or buried in something you can't see from a group chat.

WHAT YOU DO

Text him directly, not the group. Ask if he's okay before you ask where the slides are.

THE ONE WHO TOOK OVER

She's done four sections and rewritten yours.

Taking over usually comes from not believing it'll get done otherwise. Every time it slides, the belief gets stronger.

WHAT YOU DO

Claim a piece out loud with a day attached, then deliver it. That's how the belief changes.

THE ONE WHO AGREES WITH EVERYTHING

"Yeah, sounds good" to every idea.

Agreement that costs nothing tells you nothing. Sometimes it's politeness. Sometimes it's someone who thinks the plan is bad and doesn't want the fight.

WHAT YOU DO

Ask for the objection on purpose: "What's the worst part of this plan?" Get the real answer before Thursday.

Notice what those three moves have in common. They're direct, they're private, and they're about the person before the task. That's most of what conflict resolution actually is. The version that fails is the one everybody reaches for instead: posting "some people aren't pulling their weight" in the group chat and hoping the right person feels bad.

And none of it works if you start the week the project is due. The people who get help fast are the ones who gave it first, back when nothing was riding on it.

3. GET A GROUP TO ACTUALLY MOVE

Leading peers is the hardest one on the list, because you have no authority at all. Nobody made you the boss. Everyone can walk away. In a club, on a team, in a group project, the only thing you have is whether people want to go along with you. Which means leadership stops being a personality and turns into a few things you say out loud.

WHAT IT SOUNDS LIKE

Three sentences. Each one costs the person saying it something, and that's exactly why it works.

"I'll take the setup shift."

The leader takes the worst job first. Everything you ask for after that costs less.

"That was Priya's idea, and it's better than mine."

Credit given in public is the cheapest thing you will ever buy trust with.

"We're deciding this today. I say option two."

A group with no decision drifts. Somebody has to say the sentence and be the one who's wrong if it's wrong.

None of that needs a title, a personality type, or a speech. It needs you to say something true, take the hard part, and then actually do it. Do that three times in a row and people start looking at you when it's time to decide.

THE MORE HUMAN IT IS, THE HARDER IT IS TO HAND OFF.

Run the three back down the ladder and watch where AI stops. It can draft your script, and it can't stand up in front of the class. It can write the message to your teammate, and it can't be the person he trusts enough to answer. It can produce a flawless plan for Saturday, and it cannot make five people show up. That isn't a gap a better model closes. The higher you go up those three, the less of it there is to hand off.

AI can write it. It can't be the person in the room.

Say it clearly, be easy to work with, and people follow.